PILOT 01 · STORYBOARD V1 · AWAITING APPROVAL

The Claw of Syracuse

Every frame below is a still from the real 3D scene, not a sketch. The characters, ships, wall and claw machine are the production assets. I'm asking you to approve composition, story and pacing. I have not started the full render or spent any credits.

62 s · 21 shots 1080 × 1920 Narration ≈ 177 words

Sources: Polybius 8.3–8.7, Plutarch Marcellus 14–19

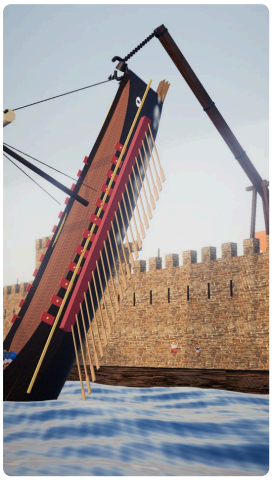
WHAT?!	OH NO!	WHOA!
0:00–0:04 · a city wall lifts a warship	0:04–0:37 · night approach, the creak, the claw, the lift, the drop	0:37–1:02 · it was a 74-year-old mathematician, and Rome ran from sticks

Storyboard

Documented stated in an ancient source

Reconstruction our design of an undocumented detail, labelled on screen Dramatised plausible staging

Invented comic beat



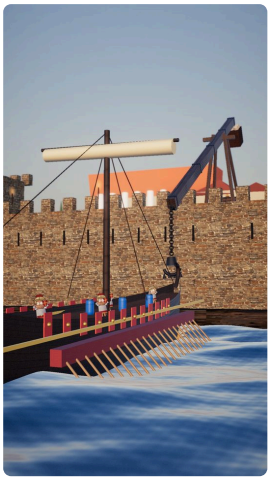
S01 0:00.0–0:03.6

Hook: the ship stands up

VO This is a Roman warship... and a city wall is picking it up.

Chain groaning, water pouring off the hull, sailors yelling. Low drum hit.

Documented Polybius 8.6.3



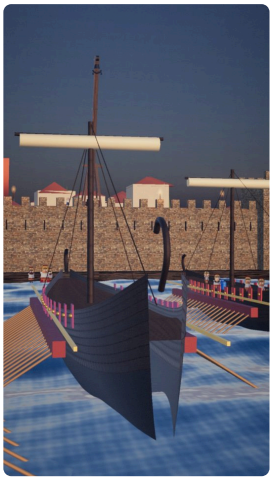
S02 0:03.6–0:04.4

Rewind

VO Rewind.

The world plays backwards: the ship drops and rows out. Rewind whoosh.

Device Storytelling device



S03 0:04.4–0:09.4

Before dawn, the fleet creeps in

VO Syracuse, 213 BC. Before dawn, Rome's fleet creeps toward the city walls.

On-screen text: SYRACUSE · SICILY · 213 BC. Oars dipping, torches on the wall.

Documented Polybius 8.5.4



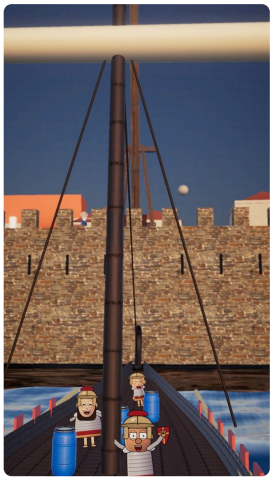
S04 0:09.4–0:11.0

Marcellus' plan

VO The plan: get so close that the city's catapults...

Marcellus whispers, smug. Officers nod.

Documented Plutarch, Marcellus 15.5



S05 0:11.0–0:13.9

Stones fly overhead

VO ...shoot right over their heads. And it works.

Stones whistle over the mast and splash far behind. The crew ducks, then grins.

Documented Polybius 8.5.4–5 (simplified)



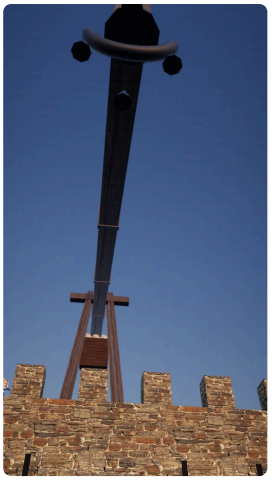
S06 0:13.9–0:16.4

Something creaks

VO Then, above them... something creaks.

Silence. Timber creak. Titus's eyes drift up.

Dramatised
Dramatisation



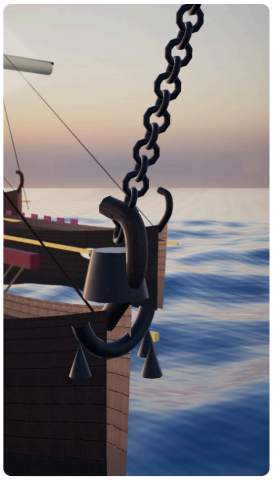
S07 0:16.4–0:20.4

The beam swings out

VO A huge beam swings out over the wall... and lowers an iron hand on a chain.

Rope strain, pulley clacks, chain rattling down.

Documented Polybius 8.5.8, 8.6.2



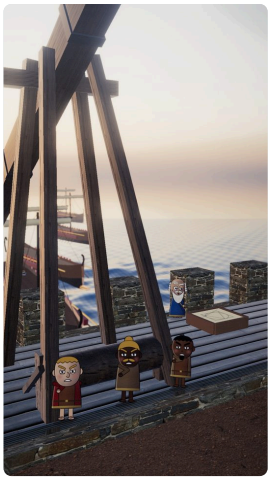
S08 0:20.4–0:22.4

The iron hand bites

VO It grabs the ship by the nose.

Iron on timber. Wood splinters.

Documented Polybius 8.6.2



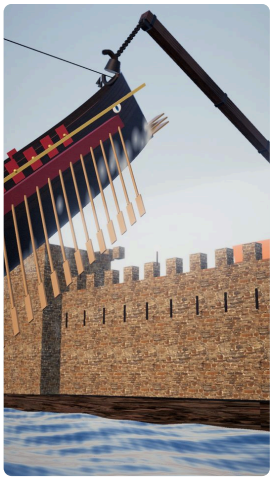
S09 0:22.4–0:25.9

Behind the wall: the lever

VO Behind the wall, the far end of the beam is pushed down, like a seesaw...

Crew heave at the windlass, the counterweight drops, Archimedes directs. On-screen label: RECONSTRUCTION.

Reconstruction
Principle: Polybius 8.6.2. Machine design: ours



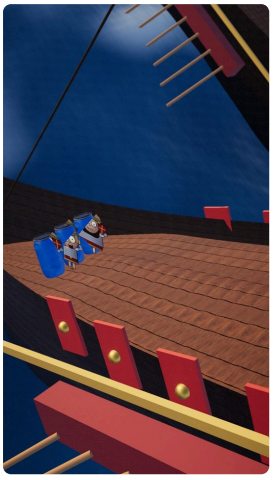
S10 0:25.9–0:28.0

The bow rises

VO ...and the front of the ship rises.

Oars dangle, water pours off the hull, the hull groans.

Documented Polybius 8.6.3



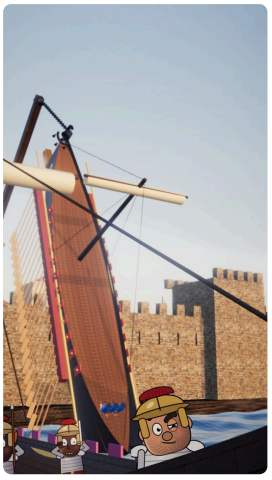
S11 0:28.0–0:29.4

The deck tilts

VO Higher...

Crew and barrels slide toward the stern.

Dramatised
Dramatisation



S12 0:29.4–0:31.6

Marcellus watches

VO ...until it's standing on its stern.

Marcellus aghast in the foreground, his ship standing upright behind him. Sunrise.

Documented Polybius 8.6.3



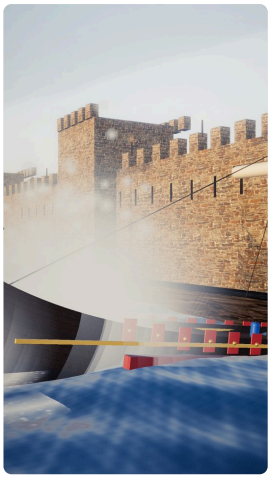
S13 0:31.6–0:33.0

Then they let go

VO Then... they let go.

Archimedes raises a finger. Pulley release snap.

Documented Release: Polybius 8.6.3. Archimedes on the wall: dramatisation



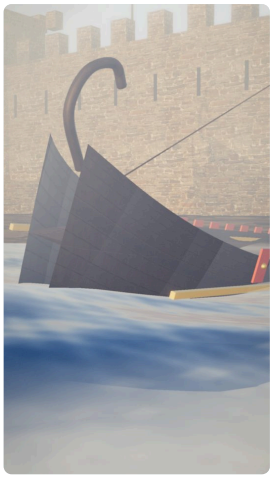
S14 0:33.0–0:36.0

The drop

VO (no narration)

Half a second of silence, then the impact: a wall of spray, then the roar of water.

Documented Polybius 8.6.4



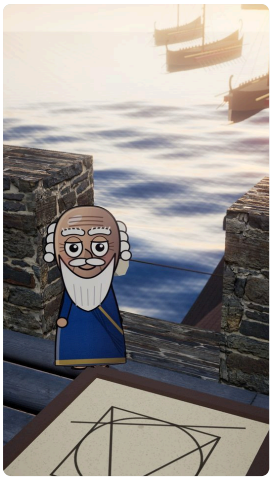
S15 0:36.0–0:37.5

Swamped

VO Some ships capsized. Most just filled with water.

The wreck settles, crew bobbing in the water.

Documented Polybius 8.6.4



S16 0:37.5–0:42.5

The mathematician

VO The genius behind it wasn't a general. He was a mathematician in his seventies: Archimedes.

Music opens up. Archimedes by his sand diagram, smiling at camera.

Documented Age: Tzetzes (c. 75 at death). Diagram: Plutarch, Marcellus 19



S17 0:42.5–0:46.5

Marcellus jokes

VO The Roman commander joked that Archimedes was using his ships to scoop up seawater...

Soaked Marcellus forces a laugh.

Documented Polybius 8.6.6; Plutarch 17.1



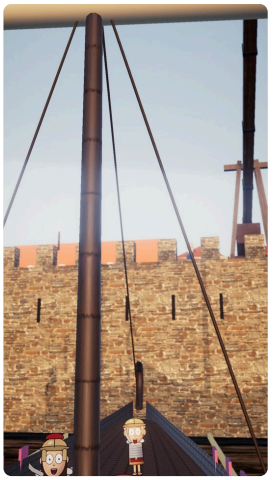
S18 0:46.5–0:49.5

Nobody laughs

VO ...his men didn't laugh.

Deadpan soldier. Water drips.

Dramatised Dramatisation



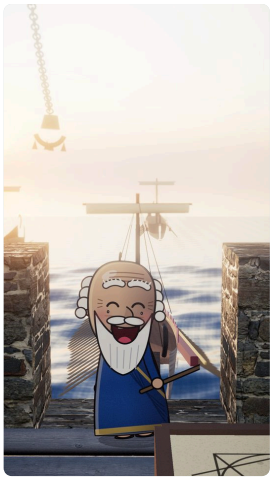
S19 0:49.5–0:53.5

Days later: 'There it is!'

VO One ancient writer says that whenever a rope or a stick poked over the wall, they screamed...

Titus, lip-synced: "THERE IT IS!" The crew panics and backs water.

Documented Plutarch, Marcellus 17.3



S20 0:53.5–0:55.5

It was a stick

VO ...and fled.

Archimedes chuckles, holding a stick, as the ships flee behind him.

Invented Invented visual joke illustrating Plutarch 17.3

S21 0:55.5–1:02.0

Rome waits

VO Rome stopped attacking the walls. It just waited... because of one old man.

The fleet anchored far out. Archimedes on the wall. Final music swell.

Documented Polybius 8.7.5–9; Plutarch 17.3

Narration script

0:00.0	This is a Roman warship... and a city wall is picking it up.
0:03.6	Rewind.
0:04.4	Syracuse, 213 BC. Before dawn, Rome's fleet creeps toward the city walls.
0:09.4	The plan: get so close that the city's catapults...
0:11.0	...shoot right over their heads. And it works.
0:13.9	Then, above them... something creaks.
0:16.4	A huge beam swings out over the wall... and lowers an iron hand on a chain.
0:20.4	It grabs the ship by the nose.
0:22.4	Behind the wall, the far end of the beam is pushed down, like a seesaw...
0:25.9	...and the front of the ship rises.
0:28.0	Higher...
0:29.4	...until it's standing on its stern.
0:31.6	Then... they let go.
0:36.0	Some ships capsized. Most just filled with water.
0:37.5	The genius behind it wasn't a general. He was a mathematician in his seventies: Archimedes.
0:42.5	The Roman commander joked that Archimedes was using his ships to scoop up seawater...
0:46.5	...his men didn't laugh.
0:49.5	One ancient writer says that whenever a rope or a stick poked over the wall, they screamed...
0:53.5	...and fled.
0:55.5	Rome stopped attacking the walls. It just waited... because of one old man.

Titus (on screen, lip-synced): "THERE IT IS!" in S19.

What the sources say

> "...when he had got hold of her by the prow, would press down the opposite end of the machine which was inside the wall. Then when he had thus by lifting up the ship's prow made her stand upright on her stern ... let the chain and hand suddenly drop." (Polybius 8.6)

> "...whenever they saw a bit of rope or a stick of timber projecting a little over the wall, 'There it is,' they cried ... and turned their backs and fled." (Plutarch, Marcellus 17)

> "...every hope of capturing the town at once if one old man of Syracuse were removed." (Polybius 8.7)

What we deliberately leave out or soften

- Plutarch has ships whirled through mid-air. Polybius, the earlier and more careful source, says the prow was lifted until the ship stood on its stern, then dropped. We show Polybius's version.
- The machine's dimensions, counterweight and windlass are not described anywhere. That shot is labelled "RECONSTRUCTION".
- Modern tests (BBC 1999, Discovery 2005) show the idea was feasible, not that it was built this way.
- A real quinquereme was about 45 m long. Ours is stylised at 30 m to read on a phone.
- No burning mirrors: that's a later legend.

Approvals needed

ITEM	TOOL	ESTIMATE
Narration, about 62 s, one voice	ElevenLabs via Higgsfield	≈ 5 credits
Character lines: "THERE IT IS!" plus a whisper	ElevenLabs via Higgsfield	≈ 1 credit
Original score, about 62 s	Music generation via Higgsfield	≈ 9 credits
3D render, captions, sound effects, mix	Our pipeline	free
Total		**≈ 15 credits (about $0.60)**

Estimates come from earlier price checks. I'll show the exact quote and wait for your yes before generating anything. A full render pass takes about 1.5–2 hours, and I expect two or three passes.

Known issues to fix in production

- S14: the impact spray reads as fog. It needs water sheets, droplets and a white column.
- S09: the lever principle needs to be clearer, with a camera move along the beam or a brief diagram overlay.
- S11 and S19: the crew are too small in frame.
- S15: the crew in the water aren't visible yet.
- S20 and S21 look too similar. S21 will become a wide over the wall to the waiting fleet.
- Ships, deck and wall need wear and texture variation to look less clean.
- Lip-sync will be checked against the recorded narration and the "THERE IT IS!" line, frame by frame.